

Astana IT University

**BALNUR BAIZHUMINOVA
SYMBAT USSUPOVA**

**The influence of the media on the formation of public opinion in the
context of military conflicts**

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Supervisor
Gulmira Shakhmetova
PhD Candidate, Senior Lecturer

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ABSTRACT

The thesis studies the strategies and methods of manipulation used by the media to influence the formation of public consciousness during military conflicts. For a detailed analysis of all aspects of media manipulation and strategies, the military conflict between Russia and Ukraine was taken as a case study. The study shows that there are various ways and processes that can distort existing information and interpret it for the personal and political purposes of both states. Using comparative content analysis and frame analysis, the study examines news articles from government and independent news sites in four countries, selected according to criteria such as political coverage, audience reach, influence on public opinion, and diversity of political views. The results show that the media often use accusatory rhetoric and manipulation techniques and strategies to shape public opinion. The research resulted in the identified manipulation strategies such as discrediting, sequential and fragmented dissemination of information, and disinformation. The most common of these was found to be the strategy of discrediting, which acts as a method of influencing society through the tactics of accusation, threat, and negative evaluation.

The conducted research was supported by the creation of a short animated film in 2D format as a presentable product aimed at highlighting an existing problem and influencing its solution. The developed 2D animated film illustrates the identified manipulation strategies and their use in the media.

The structure of the thesis is determined by the relevance, goals, objectives, object, subject and method of research, as well as the results revealed during the analysis. In addition, the development of a short animated movie in 2D format, which is a practical part of the thesis project, is described in detail. The bachelor's thesis consists of six logically connected chapters, introduction, and conclusion. The theoretical chapter includes a literature review, which allows to focus on a separate studied material within the framework of the research question. Number of illustrations - 18, tables - 6, literature sources used - 80. The total volume of the work is 45 pages.

АННОТАЦИЯ

В дипломной работе изучаются стратегии и методы манипуляции используемые СМИ с целью оказания влияния на формирование общественного сознания во время военных конфликтов. Для детального анализа всех аспектов манипулирования СМИ и стратегий в качестве примера был взят военный конфликт между Россией и Украиной. Исследование показывает, что существуют различные способы и процессы, которые могут искажать существующую информацию и интерпретировать ее в личных и политических целях обоих государств. Используя сравнительный контент-анализ и фрейм-анализ, в исследовании рассматриваются новостные статьи с правительственных и независимых новостных сайтов в четырех странах, отобранные в соответствии с такими критериями, как освещение политических событий, охват аудитории, влияние на общественное мнение и разнообразие политических взглядов. Результаты показывают, что СМИ часто используют обвинительную риторику и методы и стратегии манипулирования для формирования общественного мнения. Результатом исследования стали такие выявленные стратегии манипулирования, как дискредитация, последовательное и фрагментарное распространение информации и дезинформация. Наиболее распространенной из них оказалась стратегия дискредитации, выступающая в качестве метода воздействия на общество посредством тактики обвинения, угрозы и негативной оценки.

Проведенное исследование было подкреплено созданием короткометражного анимационного фильма в формате 2D в качестве презентуемого продукта, направленного на освещение существующей проблемы и оказание влияния на ее решение. Разработанный 2D анимационный фильм иллюстрирует выявленные стратегии манипулирования и их использование в средствах массовой информации.

Структура дипломной работы определяется актуальностью, целями, задачами, объектом, предметом и методом исследования, а также результатами, выявленными в ходе анализа. Кроме того, подробно описывается разработка короткометражного анимационного фильма в формате 2D, который является практической составляющей дипломного проекта. Бакалаврская работа состоит из шести логически связанных глав, введения и заключения. Теоретическая глава включает литературный обзор, который позволяет сосредоточиться на отдельном изучаемом материале в рамках исследовательского вопроса. Количество иллюстраций - 18, таблиц - 6, источников используемой литературы - 80. Общий объем работы составляет 45 страниц.

АНДАТПА

Дипломдық жұмыс әскери қақтығыстар кезінде қоғамдық сананың қалыптасуына әсер ету мақсатында БАҚ қолданатын манипуляциялық стратегиялар мен әдістерді зерттейді. Бұқаралық ақпарат құралдарының манипуляциялары мен стратегияларының барлық аспектілерін жан-жақты талдау үшін Ресей мен Украина арасындағы әскери қақтығыс мысал ретінде алынды. Зерттеу барысында екі мемлекеттің жеке және саяси мақсаттары үшін ақпаратты бұрмалауға бағытталған әртүрлі әдістер мен процестердің бар екені расталды. Салыстырмалы талдау мен негіздемелік талдауды қолдана отырып, зерттеу төрт елдегі үкіметтік және тәуелсіз жаңалықтар сайттарынан саяси оқиғаларды қамту, аудиторияға қол жеткізу, қоғамдық пікірге әсер ету және саяси көзқарастардың әртүрлілігі сияқты критерийлерге сәйкес таңдалған жаңалықтар мақалаларын қарастырады.

Нәтижелер бұқаралық ақпарат құралдарында қоғамдық пікірді қалыптастыру үшін айыптаушы риторика мен манипуляция әдістері мен стратегияларын жиі қолданатынын көрсетеді. Зерттеудің нәтижесі беделін түсіру, ақпаратты дәйекті және үзінді тарату және жалған ақпарат қолдану сияқты манипуляциялық стратегияларды анықтады. Олардың ішіндегі ең кең тарағаны-айыптау, қорқыту және теріс бағалау тактикасы арқылы қоғамға әсер ету тәсілі ретінде әрекет ететін беделін түсіру стратегиясы.

Зерттеу 2D форматындағы анимациялық қысқаметражды фильмді бар проблеманы қамтуға және оны шешуге әсер етуге бағытталған презентация өнімі ретінде құру арқылы нығайтылды. Анимациялық фильм зерттеу барысында анықталған манипуляциялық стратегияларды және оларды бұқаралық ақпарат құралдарында қолдануды бейнелейді.

Дипломдық жұмыстың құрылымы зерттеудің өзектілігімен, мақсаттарымен, міндеттерімен, объектісімен, пәнімен және әдісімен, сондай-ақ талдау барысында анықталған нәтижелермен анықталады. Сонымен қатар, дипломдық жобаның практикалық құрамдас бөлігі болып табылатын 2D форматындағы қысқа анимациялық фильмнің дамуы сипатталды. Бакалавр жұмысы логикалық тұрғыдан байланысты алты тараудан, кіріспе мен қорытындыдан тұрады. Теориялық тарауда зерттеу сұрағы аясында жеке зерттелетін материалға назар аударуға мүмкіндік беретін әдебиеттерге шолу бар. Иллюстрациялар саны-18, кестелер-6, Пайдаланылған әдебиеттер көздері-80. Жұмыстың жалпы көлемі 45 бет.

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DEFINITIONS

The following terms are used in the thesis:

Media	a set of communication tools including various ways of transmitting information from printed paper to digital content
Public opinion	a set of individual views, attitudes, and beliefs on a particular topic expressed by a significant part of society.
Disinformation	false information intended to deceive and mislead that a person or group of people disseminates on the Internet
Military conflict	a conflict between political powers that takes place in the form of armed confrontation, hostilities between their armed forces
Hybrid warfare	the interaction or combination of conventional and unconventional instruments of force in warfare that includes information, electronic, and cyber operations in conjunction with military action
Psychological warfare	the purposeful use by political powers of psychological means, namely propaganda, to demoralize the opponent or to break popular sentiment

INTRODUCTION

The emergence of information technology in the 20th century has indisputably influenced the development of social and international relations and the structure of communication between states. Media is an institution that builds contact with the public through the delivery of certain information from sources directly to the public [1]. New media provoked the emergence of social networks, electronic versions of traditional media (newspapers, television and radio), blogs, forums and other virtual content platforms. Their accelerated development has given rise to an information society that forms its tastes, views and habits based on various existing sources. They are the main source of attracting the attention of users as quickly as possible, giving them the opportunity to contribute to and respond to external events [2].

This has led to the fact that today the Internet is an integral part of the planning and conduct of military conflicts. Thus, the armed forces have long since begun to take into account all aspects of the information world and to control how military events are covered on the Internet. Information warfare has always been part of real warfare and includes military propaganda and disinformation [3]. Due to beautifully packaged and logically presented information, which often turns out to be false, society does not think about its actions and decisions and does not realize that these actions and decisions were instilled in them through the media. Creating stereotypes, controlling the flow of information, focusing on certain aspects and cases are elements of interaction with the public that can be used and distorted. Thus, the media can become the main source of transmitting information about the circumstances and course of events during military conflicts, thereby playing the role of a designer in forming the initial opinion and emotions of the public [4]. That is why manipulation of public opinion is one of the main problems of our time and its spread can lead to irreversible consequences in the political system of the world.

This implies **the relevance of the topic**, which lies in the fact that all of the above elements become methods of manipulation and can interact with each other, creating a certain effect on public opinion and its perception. Awareness of the details of these interactions plays a final role in orientation in the modern media platform, especially nowadays, when information directly shapes public opinion.

However, the age of technology requires the ability to adapt to them through their own ways of controlling human consciousness. According to Ghazi and Goede (2017), people's creative growth increases with the change in the creative environment [5]. Creative industry is one of the key methods of economic development and steadfastness to crises [6]. Thus, the problem of information warfare can be highlighted on the same platforms and by the same methods on

which it is based itself. 2D animation as one of the types of multimedia can draw people's attention to complex topics in an easy-to-understand format [7]. It is also used as an innovative method of teaching children, as the use of new technologies with a creative approach helps to memorize, understand, and analyze the presented information [8]. Therefore, skillful use of 2D animation can draw attention to the problem of media manipulation and warn Internet users against malicious influence on their consciousness during political conflicts.

The purpose of this study is to identify and analyze the specific methods and strategies of manipulation used by the mass media.

Research question: What strategies and methods are used by state and non-state media to shape public opinion during military conflicts?

Research object and subject:

Object: media strategies and methods used in shaping public opinion during military conflicts

Subject: creating a 2D animated short film as a means of visualizing and illustrating the influence of the media in shaping public perceptions of military encounters.

Objectives:

- 1 Considering the theoretical foundations of media influence on the formation of public opinion;
- 2 Analyzing the peculiarities of coverage of military conflicts on media platforms;
- 3 Identifying specific methods and strategies of media influence on public opinion during military conflicts;
- 4 Analyzing specific cases of using methods and strategies of media manipulation and their influence on public opinion during military conflicts by the example of the war between Russia and Ukraine;
- 5 Achieving the research goal by creating a short animated movie in 2D format;

Hypotheses:

The media employ specific storytelling methods and manipulative strategies to influence and shape public consciousness during military conflicts.

1 THEORETICAL PART

To answer the research question, it is worth delving into the concept of media manipulation and propaganda, to find out the actors of manipulation and what techniques media manipulators use. Media manipulation and propaganda began as early as World War I, when the Central and Allied Powers used the press as their main tool for propaganda [9]. By doing so, they sought support from the public and citizens of their countries. Then the Allied countries showed the German leader in a bad light [9]. Since then the media has been the main tool of manipulation. Each state has its own media in which it publishes its content and distributes it among citizens. The overwhelming influence of modern technology on international politics, consciousness, and opinion of people has made the media the fourth state [10].

In general, the basic idea of the media's impact on the public is described in agenda-setting theory [11]. The essence of the theory is that different actors in society, such as government and corporate firms, can influence what will be broadcast in the media, thus conveying their ideas and priorities [12]. Every day an agenda is set and "important" and "unimportant" news is categorized with a certain frequency of mention.

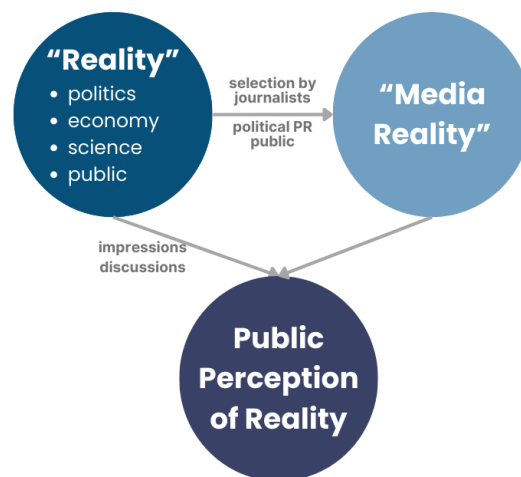


Figure 1.1 – Agenda-setting Theory

The agenda model has three stages: reality as it is (what is happening in politics, economy), "media reality" (how journalists, politicians, and society

describe reality in the media), and public perception (how the media has influenced people's view of events). To confirm the agenda-setting theory, researchers use a hybrid method of comparing media content analysis and sociological surveys [13]. In our case, the methodology chapter will analyze the content analysis of the Russian and Ukrainian media, consider the methods and strategies of manipulation and analyze the surveys to assess the impact of the media on the public perception of events.

The practical significance of the study:

Measuring the effects of media on consciousness in conditions of military conflicts requires an integrated approach that takes into account many interacting factors and their mutual influence. Thus, our research plans to provide new practical research approaches and visualizations using 2D animation, thereby expanding the understanding of the influence of media on consciousness in military conflicts and filling in all existing gaps in the literature studied below.

Various theories explain the psychological effects of animation by emphasizing people's particular reactions to the perception of information conveyed through moving objects. According to Soffar (2016), animation plays an important role in the learning process due to its visual effects, sound, and ability to engage the audience [14]. Animation truly helps people better assimilate information about complex concepts, phenomena and processes by providing visual and simple models for understanding. It simplifies complex psychological processes, making them more accessible and understandable [15]. Therefore, the ability of 2D animation to present complex concepts in a convenient form, as well as the ability to interact visually and audibly with viewers, make it an important and effective tool for delivering information. These benefits of animation were the main reason for choosing to create a 2D animated short film to demonstrate the key values of this theme.

Research methodology:

The study was conducted using the comparative content analysis and frame analysis method. These methods have long been used in all spheres of life: education, sociology, political science, communication, and documentation [16]. Content analysis is the most common method used in reviewing documents containing qualitative data [17]. It is valuable for being objective and for extracting the important and most specific data from the massive amount of material provided. Frame analysis is a method used by researchers to identify how media construct reality by interpreting events [18]. Framing is also about the way information is presented by news, from word choice to visual elements [19]. Brewer and Gross (2005) found that when presenting issues to the public, the media not only provides facts, it also provides a framework to guide readers and their thoughts in a certain direction [20]. This method can help assess how

the media functions to determine what its readers should think about an issue or incident and what their opinions will be based on [21].

The comparative content analysis and frame analysis were performed by selecting news materials about the Russian-Ukrainian military conflict. In the course of the research, the Russian, Ukrainian, and Kazakh media and world news portals of the states not involved in the conflict were considered.

Overview

The paper is divided into six chapters. The first chapter is an introduction consisting of background information, research question, research aim, objectives of the study, stated objectives, and hypothesis. The second chapter is a literature review that examines the concepts of media and hybrid warfare and their roles in public consciousness, it also explores the main theories of media manipulation during military conflicts and its examples. Chapters three, four, and five present the methodology, research findings, and analysis with a discussion section. Finally, chapter six presents a practical part describing the process of creating 2d animation.

1.1 Literature Review

What is media?

Mass media is a concept that includes television, radio, the press, the Internet and social networks, which are widely used to disseminate information. David (2021) describes the term media as social mechanisms that can influence various aspects of public opinion, including attitudes, perceptions of public support, behavioral elements of that support, and perspective information [1]. In this way, the media act as intermediaries between events and society by filtering, interpreting, and presenting information.

Public opinion

Public opinion reflects the collective views, beliefs, and perceptions of society on various issues, shaped by various factors, including the media. Previous studies have noted that it is impossible to understand the exact meaning of the term "public opinion" [22]. Public opinion about policies and events has long been at the center of scholarly and political attention, seen as an important factor in decision-making and adjustment, and as a key concept underpinning democracy. However, in their works, Dong and Lian (2021) described public opinion as a complex result of public discussions and interactions [23].

Explaining the role of media in public opinion

Public events that evoke strong emotions in people can be a catalyst for the spread of opinions through the communication media. The media play an important role in shaping the impact of these events on public opinion [24]. As Chen and Lan (2021) point out, today's media compete for audience attention by constantly saturating each individual with a stream of personalized content

designed exclusively for them [25]. Vosoughi et al. (2018) analyzed the spread of news on Twitter and found that lies spread significantly further, faster, deeper, and wider than the truth across all categories [26]. It has been found that among the many fake news, fabrication, deception, manipulation, and propaganda play a special role, which are also actively used to influence political attitudes and beliefs [27].

The main theories of media influence on public opinion during conflicts

There are theories describing the impact of the media on public opinion in the context of conflict. One of them mentioned earlier is agenda-setting theory, according to which the media not only reflects but also actively shapes the agenda by pointing out the topics that the public is thinking about [28]. During conflicts, the media often focus on certain aspects of events, drawing public attention to specific details and missing other important aspects. Such selective coverage shapes not only priorities but also distorts the overall perception of events, influencing the interests and beliefs of the audience [9]. Framing theory argues that the way information is presented to an audience affects how people perceive and process that information [29]. This implies that the media can use certain frames or contexts to make events more or less significant by influencing public perception of them.

The role of media during military conflicts

As discussed in previous studies, in the modern era, the development of technology and communications has turned the media into a double-edged instrument capable of influencing public opinion in both positive and negative ways. They are capable of both promoting peace and fuelling conflict [9]. As Warrich et al. (2021) emphasize in their work, state media is widely used as a means of influencing public opinion, including the creation of certain narratives and the dissemination of information, especially during critical periods [9]. This influence can extend to international politics and support military action.

Examples of encounters with disinformation and their consequences

There is a huge amount of research confirming the impact of media on human consciousness. For example, Reisach (2021) in his work noted cases related to this phenomenon, one of which was the US elections in 2016, where a certain number of people believed the information that Pope Francis would support Trump [30]. The data was distributed by partisan groups to attract voters who were previously interested in Trump and the Republican Party. Allcott and Gentzkow (2017) studied the incident in more detail and determined that fake news spread over the Internet, but how it affected voters turned out to be even more difficult: people are more willing to believe those stories and rumors that have a good effect on their preferred candidates [31].

The following case is considered by Rafi (2020) on the impact of viral misinformation from Brazil, Pakistan, and Mexico [32]. The WhatsApp application, which was created for communication, plays an important role in political campaigns [33]. The bottom line is that for remote places where there is no access to Wi-Fi but there is access to the telephone network, WhatsApp makes it possible to be in touch with other people, and for political advertisers this is a huge plus since voters can be contacted directly by phone number. And in other less advanced states, phone numbers can be purchased through suppliers or advertisers. This whole situation facilitates the special distribution of “state-sponsored WhatsApp content”, as well as propaganda [34]. The situation in the "Global South" is to doubt the well-informed use and decision-making in elections.

Hybrid warfare

However, the problem of media influence during the introduction of the term hybrid warfare has become especially acute. According to Magda (2016), "Hybrid warfare is a country's efforts to impose its political will on another country(s) through a combination of political, economic and informational actions and without declaring war in accordance with international law" [35]. Manipulation technologies, in turn, mean the deliberate dissemination of fake news and are one of the tools used in information warfare, which are part of the aforementioned hybrid warfare [4]. For example, during Russia's attack on Ukraine in the East, various manipulation and strategic communication technologies were used in the form of social, mass, visual, organizational, crisis, public relations, and others [36]. In the information war, ordinary unremarkable fake news and some more sophisticated ways of subconsciously influencing people's minds were used. In addition, propagandists distort historical facts in order to make people believe in their ideas and undermine confidence in the government. Russian propaganda is aimed not only at the environment of Ukraine, but also at other countries. For example, according to Kornieiev et al. (2022), at the end of 2019, Russian President Vladimir Putin distributed completely fake information about Poland and the events preceding World War II [37]. This happened at his press conference, where he justified the actions of Joseph Stalin during the attack on Poland in 1939 and accused it of seizing the territory of Czechoslovakia. Kornieiev et al. (2022) also provided an excellent example in their work on fake news spread by the Russian media regarding Petro Poroshenko, the fifth president of Ukraine. Russian media reported that Ukrainian radicals forced him to flee from his own rally held in the city of Zhytomyr during his election campaign, proving this event with an excerpt cut from an enlarged image [37]. But in fact, Petro Poroshenko went to the people to listen to their demands.

Media manipulation strategies

Over the past few years, researchers have discovered several strategies and

tactics used in the media to manipulate the public. Noam Chomsky (2018) discovered 10 strategies of media control over people and described them in his research [38]. The strategies described include distraction, problem-reaction-solution, gradual strategy, delay, treating people like children, emotion, ignorance, subduing, self-blaming, and knowing people better than yourself [38]. In the course of the study, the author concluded that the purpose of all these control strategies is to make the world as the rich and powerful want to see and know it. The tactics described earlier deprive society of critical thinking skills and autonomy.

There are also media strategies described and discovered by other researchers. For example, Zyubina et al. (2018) investigated the strategy of discrediting, Magen (2015) described the strategy of disinformation and psychological influence and Bachurin (2014) studied sequential and fragmentary ways of information dissemination [39–41]. The last four strategies will be thoroughly analyzed and described in the subsequent chapter.

What is 2D animation?

According to Dictionary.com (n.d), two-dimensional (2D) animation is defined as "animation, or a product of animation, created when two-dimensional images are rapidly sequenced to create the illusion of lifelike motion, as in traditional drawn animation, cell animation, or computer-generated vector graphics [42]." 2D animation is the art of creating motion in two dimensions. The illusion of movement is created by showing individual frames in sequence. One second typically contains 24 frames. Depending on the style of animation used, two or up to 24 separate images (24 frames per second) can appear per second [43].

Every frame of every cartoon and animated film made before the invention of computer graphics and 3D technology was drawn by animators. Nowadays, computer tools can be used to create 2D graphics and then manipulate them to create the illusion of animation [43].

Animation as a tool for information perception

Animation is a comprehensive introduction to the world of animated films, covering both traditional cartoons and computer animation [44]. According to Bhutto et al. (2018), it has nowadays become an indispensable tool for illustrating multimedia material, helping students to gain a deeper understanding of it. Therefore, animation is a powerful tool for communicating and understanding information [45]. It can effectively illustrate complex concepts and processes. In today's world, animated content can serve not only educational purposes but also be a powerful tool for raising awareness about social issues [44]. Animated videos are very effective when there is a need to spotlight a hot social or environmental issue because they tell a visually appealing story and are designed to trigger a strong emotional response [45].

Synthesis of key findings

This leads to the fact that the media either become part of the conflict and contribute to an increase in violence, or still remain on the sidelines and thus lead to a resolution of the conflict. Some media experts believe that media is a tool of soft power and shapes human thinking [46]. For example, the Cold War involving the United States and the Soviet Union led them to compete for the place of the best in music, cinema, theater, and so on [47]. Thus, these two countries have chosen a soft power strategy rather than a hard one in order to be able to influence each other's political system. The United States used soft power through its culture, lifestyle, and capitalist system to attract Soviet people. Hollywood films glorified America and associated it with the definition of freedom, openness, and democracy. This is how the media can influence human consciousness even in the most brutal times of war and does it unobtrusively and manipulatively.

All of the above studies emphasize the importance of studying public opinion as a phenomenon that includes both its institutional and normative components in order to understand the underlying mechanisms of political participation [1]. They prove that human thoughts and media are predictors of interest in collective action and the evolution of social movements. Research results have shown that publicity has a strong influence on the formation of public opinion, and digital content on understanding the dynamics of social movements [1].

Identification of under-researched aspects of the topic

When analyzing the literature that examines the influence of the media on human consciousness during military conflicts, a certain number of limitations are particularly highlighted, which do not show the completeness and vastness of knowledge in this topic. They not only highlight the existing intervals in research, but also provide an opportunity to study and fill in future works. For example, it is quite difficult to assess the aspects of the impact of media on human consciousness during this period of time, since they are also influenced by personal experience, degree of education, religious beliefs, and political identity of a person, which also interacts with each other and affects the perception of information on social networks. In addition, cultural identity, values, and traditions can form their own understanding and reaction to information, and the emotional state of a person during military conflicts can affect his ability to rationally and sensibly evaluate information provided in media resources. Fear, anxiety, and other emotional states can change perceptions, as well as affect a person's ability to adequately handle media manipulation.

Suggestion of directions for further research

Thus, measuring the effects of media on consciousness in conditions of military conflicts requires an integrated approach that takes into account many interacting factors and their mutual influence. Thus, our research plans to provide new practical research approaches and visualizations using 2D animation, thereby

expanding the understanding of the influence of media on consciousness in military conflicts and filling in all existing gaps in the literature studied above. Various theories explain the psychological effects of animation by emphasizing people's particular reactions to the perception of information conveyed through moving objects. According to Soffar (2019), animation plays an important role in the learning process due to its visual effects, sound, and ability to engage the audience [14]. Animation truly helps people better assimilate information about complex concepts, phenomena, and processes by providing visual and simple models for understanding. It simplifies complex psychological processes, making them more accessible and understandable [15]. Therefore, the ability of 2D animation to present complex concepts in a convenient form, as well as the ability to interact visually and audibly with viewers, make it an important and effective tool for delivering information. These benefits of animation were the main reason for choosing to create a 2D animated short film to demonstrate the key values of this theme.

2 DESIGN AND METHODOLOGY

The study used the comparative content analysis and frame analysis method. The research also has a “frame matrix” to define frames, consisting of descriptions of key expressions, metaphors, images, winged phrases, problems, and solutions.

To objectively assess the influence of the media on the formation of public opinion during military conflicts, the research is conducted on the study of news materials about the Russian-Ukrainian war. The sample of news portals was based on four criteria: (1) in-depth coverage of political events, (2) huge audience reach, (3) ability to lead and influence public opinion, and (4) diversity of political positions and journalistic views. Using the same criteria, state and independent news sites were selected, including articles containing the following keywords: war, Russia and Ukraine, invasion, conflict, and military action. To examine changes in the coverage of the war depending on the course of military operations, two time periods were chosen:

First period: the first 12 weeks after the outbreak of war.

Second period: the period of relative calm (August 2022 - February 2023).

The total sample consisted of 8 news portals from 4 countries. As a result, 57 news related to our topic were found, 22 of them fit all the above criteria and were analyzed.

Content analysis was conducted using the news sources described in Table 2.1.

Table 2.1 – News Sources

№	Name of newspaper	State	Headline	Date of publication
1	24 Kanal	Ukraine	The strike on the shopping mall in Kremenchug: video and all that is known about the tragedy [48]	27.06.2022
2	Channel One	Russia	Surrendered 82 Ukrainian border guards from Snake Island taken to Sevastopol [49]	26.02.2022
3	TSN	Ukraine	Serial rapists weren't as brutal as Russian soldiers - Zelensky promises to 'get every' one of them [50]	13.04.2022

4	RIA Novosti	Russia	Putin announced a special military operation in Donbass [51]	24.02.2022
5	The Guardian	UK	Russia-Ukraine war live: 'endemic corruption and poor logistics' harming Russian military, says UK – as it happened [52]	15.10.2022
6	BBC	UK	War in Ukraine: Russia launches new attacks after peace promise [53]	31.03.2022
7	Tengri News	Kazakhstan	Is there a threat of nuclear war? Opinions of Kazakhstani scientists [54]	26.09.2022
8	Sputnik	Kazakhstan	Artemivsk is being systematically surrounded [55]	27.12.2022
9	24 Kanal	Ukraine	13 Ukrainian border guards killed on Snake Island - Interior Ministry [56]	24.02.2022
10	Channel One	Russia	About 6.5 million fakes about the special operation to protect Donbass revealed on the Internet in two months [57]	25.04.2022
11	TSN	Ukraine	How to survive in a blackout without heat, water, and sewage: Lifehacks from an "extreme" coach [58]	26.11.2022
12	RIA Novosti	Russia	Putin called the emergence of nuclear weapons in Ukraine a strategic threat [59]	22.02.2022

13	The Guardian	UK	Russia-Ukraine war at a glance: what we know on day 292 of the invasion [60]	12.12.2022
14	BBC	UK	How hard will it be to defend Ukraine from Russian invasion? [61]	24.02.2022
15	Sputnik	Kazakhstan	It was inevitable: Vladimir Putin spoke out about the conflict with Ukraine [62]	21.12.2022
16	24 Kanal	Ukraine	On the Clock - 4:50: Chronology of February 24, 2022 - what was the longest day of our lives [63]	24.02.2023
17	Channel One	Russia	The monument to Zoya Kosmodemyanskaya in Chernihiv has been demolished [64]	21.04.2022
18	TSN	Ukraine	"Dirty bomb": what it is, how it is dangerous and how to protect yourself [65]	26.10.2022
19	RIA Novosti	Russia	Putin says it is known where Kyiv is making a "dirty bomb" [66]	27.10.2022
20	BBC	UK	Ukraine war: Putin says no more massive strikes - for now [67]	14.10.2022
21	Sputnik	Kazakhstan	Russian offensive in Donbass [68]	20.12.2022
22	TSN	Ukraine	Sergey Surovikin: what is known about the new commander of Russian troops in Ukraine [69]	11.10.2022

3 FINDINGS

Table 3.1 shows that 22 news articles from 8 newspapers met the criteria and contained keywords on the topic of the Russian-Ukrainian military conflict. The number of selected Ukrainian news articles exceeded the number of Russian, Kazakh, and British newspapers on the given topic. Ukrainian news publications are followed by Russian ones. As it will turn out later, Russian and Ukrainian media were most interested in disseminating articles about the war, seeking to form specific images of the opposing side. The last positions in the number of published articles related to the topic of war are occupied by the British and Kazakhstani media.

Table 3.1

Newspaper	Number of News Stories
24 Kanal	3
TSN	4
Channel One	3
RIA Novosti	3
The Guardian	2
BBC	3
Tengri News	1
Sputnik	3
Total	22

The news articles above show extensive and frequent mentions and discussions of the war in the first year after Russia invaded Ukraine, influencing agenda-setting during that time. Therefore, it is evident that these newspapers frequently published news articles on the given topic of war crimes in Ukraine and gave importance to the issue, subsequently making the issue more "alive" in the minds of their readers.

The framing effect is a cognitive distortion in which human perception depends directly on the form and manner in which information is presented [70]. Each newspaper has its own "framing effect" that authors focus on while writing articles. Figure 3.1 presents all the auxiliary frames that were used to enhance the discourse about the Russian-Ukrainian war in the 22 news articles analyzed below. The auxiliary frames were identified using the frame matrix presented in Table 3.2.

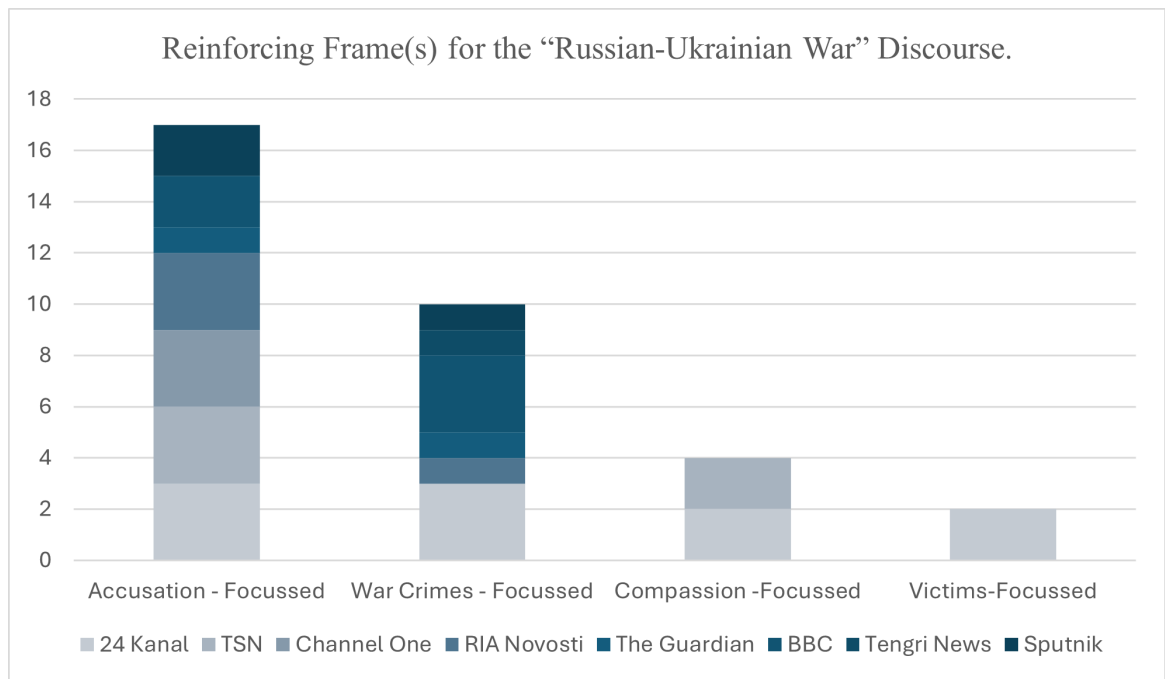


Figure 3.1

As can be seen in Figure 3.1, the accusation-focused frame dominated the newspapers. The number of publications based on this frame is 17 out of 22 (77%), also the frame “war crimes-focused” occupies a significant number of news articles - 10 publications (45%), followed by the frames “compassion-focused” - 2 (9%) and “victims-focused” - 2 (9%).

Table 3.2 includes a detailed analysis of each news article, identifying the core position, key phrases, and rhetoric used in the article, the source of the problem, the intended solution, and the attributed proposition. The results obtained will help to answer the research questions, thereby assessing the public perception of news on the topic of the Russian-Ukrainian war and identifying the methods of manipulation used by the mass media.

Table 3.2 – Framing Matrix

№	Core Position	Catch-Phrases/Rhetoric	Source of Problem	Implied Solution	Attributed Proposition
1	Russian occupiers shelled a shopping mall in Ukraine	Russian theor, Russian killers, “women and children screaming, limbs are blown off”, “terrorists should have no place on earth”, deadly shell, “Russian propagandists lie”, “Russians rejoice and gloat “pour Ukrainian blood over everything”, cynical warfare (war crimes-focussed, compassion-focussed, accusation-focussed, victims-focussed)	Russian occupiers	Life imprisonment of Russian occupiers, increasing pressure on the “terrorist state” and increasing support for Ukraine with weapons	Endorsed (“Chairman of the Poltava Regional Military Administration Dmitry Lunin immediately confirmed...”, “Vladimir Zelensky revealed...”, “Polish President Andrzej Duda also holds a similar opinion...”)
2	Ukraine declared its living soldiers heroically dead	Ukrainian myths, “Ukraine buried alive”, horror, propaganda, sheer lies, “Zelensky is very believable...” (accusation-focussed)	Ukrainian propaganda	Exposing Ukrainian myths/distrust of Ukrainian media	Nonendorsed (“Mikhail Yasnikov, deputy commander of the Black Sea Fleet, reported...”)
3	Crimes of the Russian army on the territory of Ukraine	Russian army atrocities, war criminals, horrible crimes, inhuman cruelty, rape, perverts, “we’ll get everyone”, serial rapists (compassion-focussed, accusation-focussed)	Russian army	Prosecution	Nonendorsed (“...assured the president”)

4	Ukrainian shelling of Donbas militias, Putin's forced decision on special military operation in Donbass	demilitarization, genocide, bloody crimes, "constant threat coming from Ukraine", Nazis, "neo-Nazis have seized power in Ukraine", power paralysis, Ukrainian aggression (accusation – focussed, war crimes - focussed)	Ukrainian government	Demilitarization of Ukraine	Nonendorsed ("...he said")
5	Corruption hampering Russian military progress	"endemic corruption and poor logistics", Russia's "poor performance" in Ukraine (accusation – focussed)	Russian corruption	N/A	Nonendorsed ("The UK Ministry of Defence also said...", "It said...")
6	Russian attacks continue despite a government pledge to scale back military action	attacks, war crimes, "the morgues are full", "part of the civilian infrastructure was destroyed", Russian shelling (war crimes – focussed, accusation – focussed)	Russian aggression and vandalism, Putin	N/A	Nonendorsed ("a spokesperson for Ukraine's armed forces, said...", "the official said...", "The BBC has not been able to confirm this independently, but residents of Chernihiv also said...")
7	There is a possibility of a nuclear strike by Russia because of the war with Ukraine	"The Russia-Ukraine situation is very serious", nuclear bomb, "it will be bad if they completely lose their heads", "everyone will die out", "a nuclear strike by Russia is possible as a response to aggression from	Russian-Ukrainian war	N/A	Endorsed ("expert answering the question of the correspondent of Tengrinews.kz said...")

		outside"(war crimes - focussed)			
8	Russia has taken control of Artemivsk	"puppet" Kyiv regime, "everything is in vain, losses are irreplaceable", cata-strophe, "Ukrainian troops are being thrown into the cauldron of death by the thousands", "prerequi-sites for a global nuclear conflict", corrupt society (war crimes-focussed)	Russia	N/A	Nonendorsed ("Former U.S. Senator Col. Richard Black previously stated...", "Deputy Commander of the LNR Army Corps Apty Alaudinov today stated...")
9	Russian occupants killed Ukrainian border guards	"an enemy Russian ship", "the enemy has killed" (accusation-focussed, compassion-focussed, victims-focussed)	Russian occupiers	Prosecution	Nonendorsed ("...according to Anton Gerashchenko, Advisor to the Minister of Internal Affairs")
10	Fake information about Russia from Ukraine, Poland, Latvia, USA, UK are spreading across the Internet	information warfare, false reports, "dehumanizing the image of Russians", disinfor-mation, lies, "covering up war crimes", "covering up the killing of Donbas residents" (accusation-focussed)	Ukraine and its allied countries	Distrust of foreign media	Nonendorsed ("...noted Ekaterina Mizulina")
11	Survival Lifehacks for Ukrainians during the war	survival, constant shelling, danger (compassion-focussed)	Russia, Putin	N/A	N/A
12	The emergence of tactical nuclear weapons in	strategic threat, nuclear weapons (accusation-focussed)	Ukraine	Seizing Ukraine, depriving it of the ability to use nuclear	Endorsed ("According to the memorandum, the Russian Federation, the

	Ukraine is a strategic threat to Russia			weapons		United Kingdom and the United States confirm. . .)
13	Russia commits war crimes in Ukraine (292 days after the invasion)	explosions, casualties, Russian attacks, “tough power supply conditions “sexual crimes committed by Russian troops” (war crimes-focussed)	Russia	Prosecution		Nonendorsed (“Girkin said. . .”, “Serhiy Gaidai, governor of the Russian-occupied Luhansk region, said. . .”)
14	Russia is winning the war	Russia’s attack, “Ukrainians are in a very difficult situation”, “extremely bloody”, assassinations of leaders, “maneuver” warfare, survival (war crimes-focussed)	Russia, Russia’s superiority in artillery	N/A		Nonendorsed (“Jack Watling says. . .”, “Mr Barry says. . .”)
15	Vladimir Putin said that the conflict with Ukraine was inevitable	coup d’état, tragedies, loss of life, hostilities, military operations (accusation-focussed)	Western leaders	N/A		Nonendorsed (“Putin said. . .”)
16	Russia’s war crimes on the day of the invasion	genocide, bombing, “rocket fire on Ukrainian territories”, victims, trap, captivity, series of assassination attempts, nuclear disaster, “burned Russians”, worst enemy (war crimes-focussed, accusation-focussed)	Russia	War trial	crimes	Endorsed (“Channel 24 reconstructed the events. . .”)
17	Ukrainians are Nazis who tore down the monument	nazis, “war on Ukraine monuments”, destruction (accusation-	Ukraine	Prosecution		N/A

	to Zoya focussed) Kosmodemyan- skaya				
18	Russia prepares 'dirty bomb' attack on Ukraine	terrorist attack, "Russian propaganda media", "Russians often accuse others of what they plan themselves", theft, intimidation (accusation-focussed)	Russia, Russian propaganda media	Distrust of Russian media	Endorsed ("Knowing how often Russia blames Ukraine for things it then does itself, it's worth learning more about the term...")
19	Ukraine creates 'dirty bomb' and prepares attack on Russia	nuclear fuel, "dirty bomb", "Moscow knows where it's made"(accusation-focussed)	Ukraine	Seizing Ukraine; depriving it of the ability to use nuclear weapons	Nonendorsed ("Putin said...")
20	Russia's war crimes on the territory of Ukraine continue	massive strikes, heavy bombing, "a wave of strikes across Ukraine", riots, injuries (war crimes-focussed, accusation-focussed)	The Russian government, Putin	N/A	Endorsed ("The BBC has also found evidence...")
21	Russia has the right to attack Ukraine	"aggressive rhetoric of the West", "ordered" pictures, "firing squad"law, "Ukraine is losing the war with Russia threats, Kyiv's "puppets", "recklessly greedy representatives of the military-industrial complex"(accusation-focussed)	Kyiv regime, aggressive rhetoric of the West	Ukraine and U.S. retreat	N/A
22	The new commander of Russian troops in	missile explosions, "there are dark spots in his biography", "twice	Russia, Gen. Sergei Surovikin	N/A	Endorsed ("The material is based on an article by TheGuardian")

Ukraine is a	arrested”,	(new
ruthless man	corruption, cruelty,	commander
	“he will be stained	of the
	from head to toe	Joint
	with the blood of	Group of
	Ukrainians”	Forces)
	(accusation-	
	focussed)	

Table 3.2 indicates the prevalence of accusations and condemnations towards Russia in the newspapers. This can be seen in such key phrases as “Russian killers”, “Russian theor”, "Russian propagandists lie "an enemy Russian ship "Russians rejoice and gloat "pour Ukrainian blood over everything “serial rapists” etc. The Russian army, Russian occupiers, Russian corruption, and the Russian authorities are mostly identified as the source of problems. The supposed solution that the authors of the news articles refer to and suggest is to hold Russia and its authorities accountable for the crimes committed.

In addition, the media widely use compassion, pity, and sympathy in the publication of war-related news. This is manifested through such catchphrases as "women and children screaming, limbs are blown off“the morgues are full”, “part of the civilian infrastructure was destroyed”. The use of the emotional aspect can short-circuit rational thinking and, ultimately, critical perception of the information presented. Compassion and other emotions, a frequent manipulative strategy, allow the brain to unconsciously instill ideas, desires, fears, and anxieties [38]. Thus, in the column “Source of the Problem” one can notice that the newspapers often referred to Russian President Putin as the person responsible for all the suffering of the Ukrainian people, which was mentioned in the catchphrases.

The Western media is also negative towards the Russian government and supports Ukraine not only by supplying arms, ammunition and other military engineering, but also through published news. The reviewed news papers BBC (38 million readers) and The Guardian (20.8 million readers) are among the largest publishers in the world. According to PressGazette statistics for March 2024, the BBC ranks first in engagement (9.4 billion minutes) and The Guardian ranks third (1 billion minutes), indicating their wide audience reach and ability to influence their perception of news [71]. Thus, if we look at Table 3, we can also notice how the West interprets the events that occurred on the territory of Russia and Ukraine, namely by using such rhetoric as “attacks”, “war crimes”, “endemic corruption and poor logistics”, “sexual crimes committed by Russian troops” and so on. However, unlike the Ukrainian media, the Western media, despite hinting at Russia’s criminal acts and blaming them for the incidents, do not openly point out how the problem can be solved. While Ukrainian news portals directly refer

to Russia and claim that it is necessary to defeat the rival country, using phrases such as “Ukrainian partners should react...”, “Russia should be recognized as a terrorist state”, “Knowing how often Russia accuses Ukraine of what it then does itself, it is worth learning more about the ‘dirty bomb’”, then BBC and The Guardian use a manipulative “downgrade” strategy [48,65]. Zyubina et al. (2018) explain downgrading strategy as the analysis of situations that implies an implicit negative attitude towards what is being described and is conducted using certain tactics [39]. It can be seen from the headlines of the analyzed articles: “Endemic corruption hampering Russian military progress, says UK MoD”, “War in Ukraine: Russia launches new attacks after peace promise”, “Russian President Vladimir Putin has said there is no need for more massive strikes on Ukraine, days after the heaviest bombardment of the country since the war began”.

Russian news newspapers, on the contrary, accuse Ukraine of provocations, propaganda, and disinformation and shift responsibility for the outbreak of war onto it. They often refer to President Putin and his statements and use expressions such as "Nazis "genocide "Ukrainian aggression". In one of their articles, they accused Ukraine of disinformation, pointing out that it had "buried"its living soldiers to make Russia villains and bloodthirsty murderers in the eyes of the public [49]. For them, the source of the problem is Ukraine and its policies, as well as Western states that support Ukraine. The proposed solution is the subordination of the territories of Ukraine to Russia.

When paying attention to the Kazakh media, you can see how carefully the authors choose their words so as not to condemn any of the available parties. The articles are supported by facts without the intervention of personal opinion. It is no secret that Kazakhstan is an economically dependent ally of Russia. President Kassym-Jomart Tokayev declares that he does not take the side of Russia or Ukraine, calls for peace, and also speaks about the "principle of indivisibility of Eurasian security" [72].

Table 3.3 – Newspapers vs. Attributed Proposition

<i>Newspaper</i>	<i>Endorsed</i>	<i>Disendorsed</i>	<i>Nonendorsed</i>
<i>TSN</i>	2	0	2
<i>24 Kanal</i>	2	0	1
<i>Channel One</i>	0	0	3
<i>RIA Novosti</i>	1	0	2
<i>The Guardian</i>	0	0	2
<i>BBC</i>	1	0	2

<i>Newspaper</i>	<i>Endorsed</i>	<i>Disendorsed</i>	<i>Nonendorsed</i>
<i>Tengri News</i>	1	0	0
<i>Sputnik</i>	0	0	3
<i>Total</i>	7	0	15

Table 3.3 shows that out of 22 news articles, only 7 were endorsed by newspaper authors/journalists. This means that the authors of the articles agreed and endorsed the words of those referred to in the written publication. 15 newspapers, in turn, took a neutral position - the publications had references and citations, but the authors did not express an opinion about them. It should be noted that not a single article refuted the statements referred to, most of which were about Russian war crimes. None of the 22 authors of the analyzed articles spoke negatively about the accusations and condemnations against Russia and its policies. This proves the agenda theory: newspapers create stories to promote readers' understanding of Russia's war crimes against Ukraine in a certain direction [13].

4 ANALYSIS AND DISCUSSION

To answer the research question, a more detailed content analysis should be conducted and the manipulative strategies used by the media to influence human consciousness during war should be examined. From the 22 news articles examined above, 4 main manipulative strategies were identified: sequential and fragmented ways of disseminating information, disinformation and psychological influence, discrediting strategy [39–41].

Figure 4.1 shows that the most common strategy is the strategy of discrediting - 21 news articles (64%), the sequential way of information dissemination occupies the next position - 6 publications (18%), followed by misinformation - 3 articles (9%), and the most uncommon strategy - fragmented way of information dissemination - 2 articles (6%).

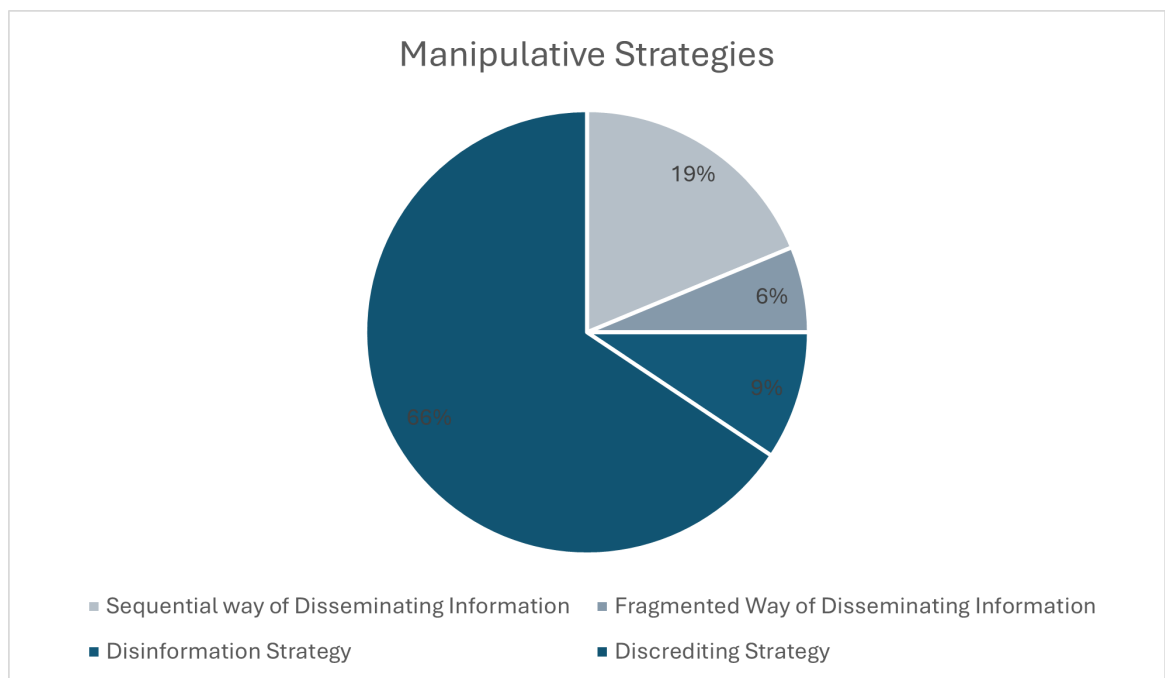


Figure 4.1

Each strategy mentioned will be broken down below with examples from the news articles reviewed.

Sequential and fragmented ways of disseminating information

Mass media is the main channel of influence on mass consciousness in modern society. “Before they used to prepare artillery before an attack,” says Dmitry Kiselyov, a Russian TV presenter and head of a new government news agency, “but now they prepare information” Actors who control the media set the direction of information waves. They decide which events should be given the most importance and which should be presented as unimportant or even hidden [41]. Thus, the

trends, conditions, directions and limitations of the use of military-political discourse are formed and set. The media use two main methods of presenting information to have the necessary cognitive impact on the individual: sequential and fragmented. While the sequential approach analyses information in detail and comprehensively according to an established topic, the fragmented approach is an incomplete, partial presentation of information [41]. Using such fragmented information makes it difficult for an untrained person to form a holistic image of the events and phenomena described. Due to this, the owner of the information source gets wide opportunities to manipulate the audience, changing the real picture of the world to a more convenient one for himself, omitting some events or, on the contrary, glorifying others [73].

To examine the impact of these strategies in more detail, let us take as examples the incidents of the rocket attack on a shopping center in Kremenchug and the demolition of a monument to a hero of the Great Patriotic War in Chernihiv. The first news, taken from the Russian press, is an example of fragmentation, while the Ukrainian news is consistent. On the afternoon of June 27, the Amstor shopping center in Kremenchug was hit by a rocket attack. The news portal 24tv.ua published a report under the headline "Attack on shopping center in Kremenchuk: video and everything that is known about the tragedy". Below is the text of that report:

"Vladimir Zelensky said during an evening performance on June 27 that one of the most daring terrorist attacks in the history of Europe had been committed in Russia. About a thousand people were in the shopping center before the air alert was announced. Fortunately, when they were informed of the danger, many of them managed to get out. At the same time, at the time of the missile attack, many people remained in the shopping center: employees and visitors. Rescuers reported that the fire covered 10,000 square meters. 115 firefighters and 20 units of equipment were involved in extinguishing the fire. A fire train of "Ukrzaliznytsia" and MOG of the State Emergency Service were also sent to the place of the incident. At lunchtime on June 28, Interior Minister Denis Monastyrski announced that 18 people had been killed in the strike. In addition, the remains of 7 bodies were found at the scene. A DNA test will be conducted to identify them. Among the injured, there is a child with serious traumas. He is currently under the supervision of doctors. A total of 59 people with mine blast injuries, including concussion, have applied to the medics. However, this number may increase, as some of the victims felt the deterioration of their condition only on the second day" [48]

A news article published by Channel One reported on the Ukrainians who destroyed the monument to Zoya Kosmodemyanskaya. Here is what the article says:

"In Chernihiv, Nazis calling themselves "territorial defense" demolished a monument to Zoya Kosmodemyanskaia. The statue was installed in the schoolyard. The monument was toppled over and destroyed. The war with monuments to the heroes of the Great Patriotic War has been going on in Ukraine for many years. Just recently, militants demolished a bust of Marshal Zhukov in Kharkiv"

[64]

Both texts have a common theme - the description of war crimes that took place in Ukraine. However, the structure, level of detail and content of the texts differ significantly. The text of the Russian news portal is characterized by brevity, conciseness, and lack of more detailed information about the situation. Such text structuring is necessary to create a superficial and fragmentary picture of what happened in the reader's mind. In contrast to the above example, the text of the Ukrainian press covering the tragedy that occurred in Ukraine on June 27 is characterized by a high degree of detail, the use of a large number of negative vocabulary, especially verbs, and phrases such as "daring terrorist attack", "remains of bodies", "mine blast wounds", "concussion" and so on. The news report also provides all the detailed information about the incident, which allows viewers to feel the tragedy. Thus, we can conclude that this text, in addition to its main task of providing information, also performs an attitudinal function, forming the audience's attitude towards the participants of the event and the situation as a whole.

Disinformation strategy

One of the most sensitive areas of intelligence services is psychological warfare, deliberate leaks, misinformation, and the use of media material to intimidate [40] . "Disinformation" can be defined as "the part of misinformation that is deliberately disseminated" and therefore "intended to mislead" [74]. Mandić and Klarić (2023) argue that with the current information balance, disinformation messages are ammunition and non-lethal weapons in modern information warfare, which aims to subdue rather than persuade the enemy [75]. Before Russia invaded Ukraine, both sides were engaged in active warfare, using various methods ranging from propaganda and disinformation to censorship and cyberattacks to boost the morale of their troops, demoralize the enemy, and bring the international community to their side [76]. Thus, the strategy of managing true, half-true, or false information served as a powerful method for intelligence agencies on both sides to shape the agenda for the general public and politicians.

This method was used by Ukraine and Russia in several ways. According

to the Associated Press (2023), even before the outbreak of hostilities, Russia resorted to disinformation, making several false accusations against the Ukrainian government [77]. A media campaign to discredit Ukraine has been launched in the Russian information space, including accusations of genocide of the Russian-speaking population and the dissemination of fake videos of civilian casualties. Thus, the goal of the Russian side is to create a pretext for the invasion and justify these actions, while the Ukrainian narrative is mainly focused on gaining international support [78].

A party whose defense capabilities are lower than the opponent's usually resorts to online warfare, using the media as a tool to counter attacks. Ukraine's success in the confrontation with Russia is not only due to military force, but also to other factors, among which a special place is occupied by information warfare, which Ukraine is waging very successfully [79]. A good example of this is the situation that took place on February 24 on the "Snake" island. At the end of the first day of the war, Snake Island came under the control of Russian troops. The news channel 24tv.ua, reported that according to Ukrainian authorities, 13 border guards defending the island were killed in the attack after refusing to lay down their arms. In a report with the loud headline "13 Ukrainian border guards killed on 'Snake' island" published by the Interior Ministry, adviser to Interior Minister Anton Herashchenko said:

"This was followed by a rocket and artillery strike. Thirteen Ukrainian border guards died. Perhaps the brave hero who sent the superior enemy further away, as the "Zaporizhian Cossacks" sent the enemies of Ukraine, also died" [56]

Ukrainian propaganda through the media successfully presented a negative view of Russia's brutality during the invasion of Ukraine, which claimed many lives and caused serious damage [80]. For its part, the Russian side stated that all information about the dead Ukrainian border guards on Snake Island was "propaganda" and "complete lies." In particular, the news portal "First Channel" (1tv.ru) said:

"The fact is that Ukraine officially buried these guys alive and even managed to award them posthumously. This is horror and propaganda, a total lie." [49]

Ukrainian propaganda aimed at gaining the support of the world's population should also be subjected to a more thorough check on the veracity of the information disseminated. Numerous cases of fake photos and videos that do not correspond to real events indicate the need for more careful verification of such materials [80].

Discrediting Strategy

Discrediting strategy is the most frequently used manipulative technique in

modern political discourse [39]. It includes analysis - “minus”, which is based on the analysis of situations that imply a hidden negative attitude to what is being described and is conducted with the help of certain tactics. Thus, the discrediting strategy includes the following tactics:

- 1 **Negative evaluation tactic** - aimed at pointing out the individual’s responsibility for the reprimanded action;
- 2 **Accusation tactic** - blame is attributed to a certain person for committing unfavorable deeds, actions, or qualities;
- 3 **Threat tactic** - indicates the negative result of the opponent’s committing certain actions (mainly manifested in words, and deeds);

Figure 4.2 shows that of the 21 news articles written using the discredit strategy, the negative evaluation tactic is the most common with 12 articles (57%), followed by the accusation tactic with 7 articles (33%), and the threat tactic with 2 articles (10%).

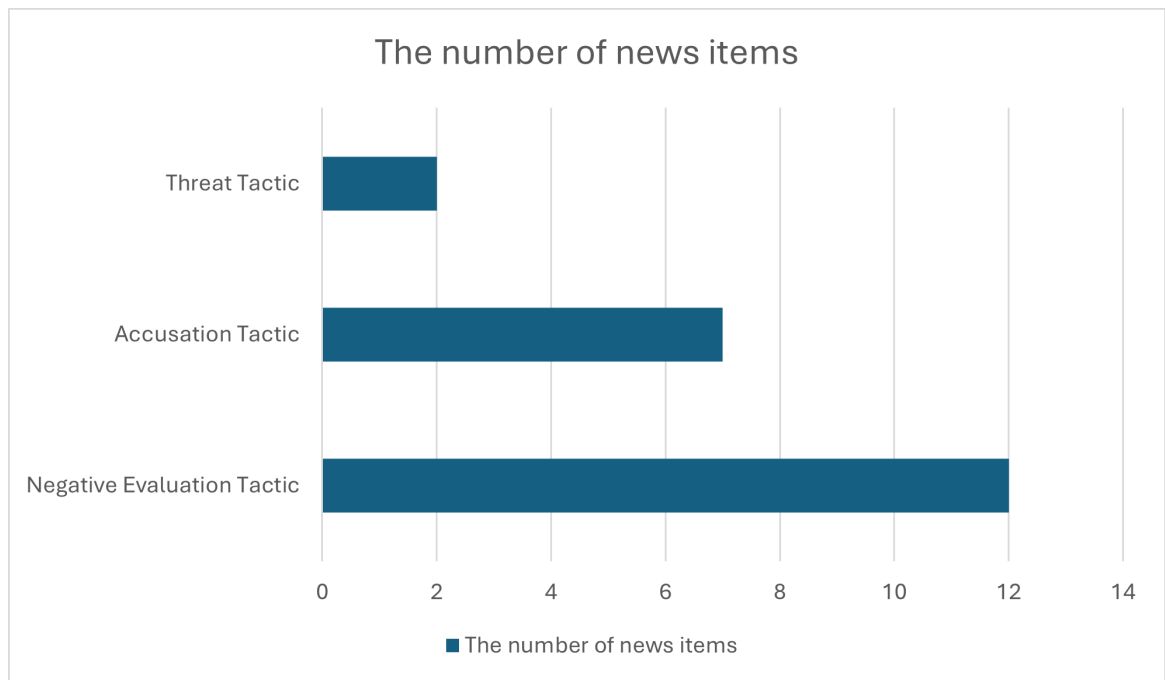


Figure 4.2

Below each of the above tactics will be considered in a more detailed context and supported by examples from the analyzed news articles.

Negative Evaluation Tactic

As written earlier, this tactic highlights a specific action or behavior that is deemed unacceptable or reprehensible. These accusations are made based on the manipulator’s ideas about ethical norms and moral education.

For example, as published by the news portal RIA Novosti, in his address to the nation on February 24, 2022, Russian President Vladimir Putin called the

country a “neo-Nazi” state as justification for invading Ukraine:

"Dear comrades! Your fathers, grandfathers, and great-grandfathers fought the Nazis and defended our common homeland not for today's neo-Nazis to seize power in Ukraine. You swore an oath of allegiance to the Ukrainian people, not to the anti-people junta that is robbing Ukraine and mocking this very people" [51]

Accusation Tactic

In this tactic, the emphasis is usually on identifying and highlighting fictional or real mistakes or shortcomings in the actions and deeds of the other party [39]. Examples include: pointing out specific mistakes or failures in the opponent's actions; emphasizing negative aspects; referring to scandalous events that occurred in the past, and finally, using accusations to manipulate public opinion to achieve political or strategic goals.

For example, in an article published in the RIA Novosti newspaper, on February 22, 2022, Russia accused Ukraine of trying to build a “dirty” nuclear bomb. Vladimir Putin stated:

"What is the threat to us. In that even the appearance of tactical nuclear weapons in Ukraine means a strategic threat for us. This is what we should keep in mind" [59]

As published by the same news portal, on October 27 of the same year, he said that Moscow roughly knows where this is being done. At a plenary session of the Valdai International Discussion Club, Putin said:

"It's not by accident that we have released data from the intelligence services about some so-called “dirty bomb” incident being prepared. We even know where it's being done. The remnants of nuclear fuel have been transformed a little bit. The technologies available in Ukraine allow this to be done" [66]

Threat Tactic

Another tactic, threats, is to instill fear and create the effect of no return to the previous state [39]. As a rule, in the modern political world, a threat can provoke conflict and can be an emotional or retaliatory reaction to an action committed by a third party [39].

Thus, on April 13, 2022, Ukrainian news portal TSN published an article with threatening words of President Volodymyr Zelensky promising to find every war criminal who committed lawlessness on the territory of Ukraine:

"Not all serial rapists reached the level of brutality that Russian soldiers reached. Certainly, we will establish the full truth about all of these abusers. No matter how much time and effort it takes, we will find them all" [50]

5 PRACTICAL PART

5.1 CREATING A 2D ANIMATED FILM

During military conflicts, the media may be a very effective instrument for manipulating public opinion and influencing people's attitudes and actions. A range of deceptive tactics are employed by the media to sway public opinion, frequently at the emotional level.

This practical part of the diploma thesis will explore and demonstrate the principles of one of the manipulative strategies used by the media. The project involves the creation of a 2D animation illustrating how the media manipulate information and influence people's perceptions during military conflicts. The aim of the work is to familiarise viewers with the mechanisms of manipulation and increase their media literacy.

The object of research in this paper is media strategies and manipulation techniques used in military conflicts. In the process of creating the animated film, various animation techniques and narrative approaches were used to present the researched topic in the most accurate and comprehensible way. An important aspect of the work is to carefully analyse existing manipulation strategies in order to create a credible and compelling product that can inform and educate the audience.

The aim of this animation is not only to demonstrate how media manipulation works, but also to develop critical thinking in viewers, which will ultimately help them to better absorb information in the media space. The process of creating 2D animation includes several stages: pre-production, production, and post-production (Figure 5.1). Each stage has its own importance and complexity, which determine the quality and success of the final product. In this chapter, we will look in detail at each of these stages and their interrelationships in the animation creation process.

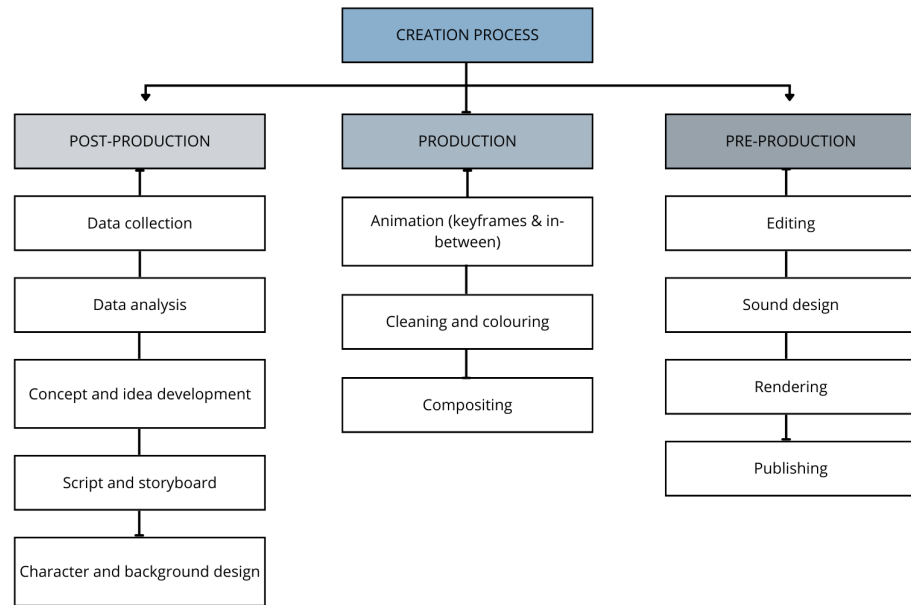


Figure 5.1 – Process of creating 2D animation

Pre-Production

This stage considered the data collected related to the research topic based on the literature review and in line with the findings outlined in the methodology chapter. The next stage included the creation of the concept and story idea and the development of the storyboard according to the script. The character design and animation backgrounds were also included in this stage.

Production

This stage marks the beginning of the animation creation process. It begins with the creation of a rough cut including keyframes. After this initial stage, a "clean animation" is created. This clean animation includes in-between frames, which improves the overall quality of the animation. The next steps in this stage include colouring and colour correction. Finally, the last process of this stage is compositing, which helps to seamlessly connect the different elements of the animation.

Post-production

Post-production is the stage of finalizing an animation before it is released. This stage includes editing, colour correction, sound design and rendering. Final editing of the animation and final sound adjustments were made. The last step was to check the animation for any mistakes and make the necessary corrections.

5.2 PROCESS OF CREATING AN ANIMATED FILM

5.2.1 Data collection and data analysis

The process of creating an animation starts with the careful collection and analysis of data that will be used to develop the concept and script. In the context of this project, this included researching news channels and other media sources covering military conflicts. The data collection and analysis stage is very important for the entire project as it determines the direction and content of the future animation and ensures that the content created is scientifically sound and relevant.

As a result of analyzing the collected data, four main manipulation strategies used by the media in covering the military conflicts between Ukraine and Russia were identified. These strategies formed the basis for the development of the animation concept. Based on the data collected, the main goal was to show viewers specific examples of manipulation used by the media. The aim was to create educational content that not only informs but also encourages viewers to think critically about the information they receive.

5.2.2 Concept and idea of the animation

The collection and analysis of data had a significant impact on the concept and idea of the animation. Key moments and scenes were identified that clearly illustrate one of the identified techniques, the disinformation strategy. The main idea was defined to demonstrate the process of reporting manipulative content through the media, which contains the principles of how the disinformation strategy works. This allowed the animation to be not only informative but also interactive, immersing the viewer in the process of manipulation and making them think about how they can affect themselves in this way.

5.2.3 Script and storyboard

After defining the concept and idea, the next stage of Pre-production was script development and storyboarding. These stages are key to turning the animation concept into a detailed visual project. The script defines the story, while the storyboard helps to visualize each scene, making the animation process more organized and structured. The animation script is built on the basis of the identified manipulation strategies and is intended to demonstrate their influence on the viewer's perception. For a more detailed description, the script can be divided into several acts:

Act 1:

The action begins in the midst of a battle. A wounded soldier seeks shelter on the battlefield. Suddenly, an enemy soldier appears in front of him. The scene freezes and we see a man sitting in front of the television. He switches channels and is confronted with sharply contrasting accounts of the same event.

Act 2:

The first channel presents the rescue of a wounded soldier as an act of great heroism. The screen is filled with bright colors and slow-motion footage, creating an atmosphere of courage and compassion. Not satisfied with what they see, the viewer switches to another channel. On the second channel, the same event is shown in gloomy colors. Dark filters and sullen facial expressions turn the rescue operation into an insidious trap, creating an atmosphere of suspicion and fear. Confused, the protagonist returns to the previous channel.

The heroic narrative continues, but the viewer's confusion grows. Unable to make sense of the various interpretations, he turns off the television, plunging the room into darkness. Seeking clarity, he opens the curtains, letting in the light and illuminating everything around him.

Act 3:

To his surprise, he sees a film set outside his window. The dramatic scenes he has just seen on television are being filmed right before his eyes. The heroes and villains, who a moment ago were pitted against each other, are now laughing and talking between takes. In amazement, he realises that he has become a spectator of a brilliant illusion, a reminder of the fine line between reality and fiction.

A storyboard is an important tool for visualizing the script and organizing the sequence of frames. Each scene was originally drawn as simple sketches. These sketches include the main elements of the action, key character poses and the positioning of objects in the frame. Once the sketches were created, they were arranged in a sequence that reflected the development of the story. This helped to visualise the transitions between scenes and ensure a smooth narrative. Each frame of the storyboard was detailed, including guidelines for lighting, camera angles and characters' emotional expressions. This allowed for a more accurate visualisation of how each scene would look in the final animation.



Figure 5.2 – Storyboard snippet

5.2.4 Creating character and background designs

After defining the script and storyboard, the next important step in the Pre-production animation process is to create the character and background designs. This stage plays a key role in conveying the emotion and meaning of the animation, so careful attention is paid to all the details and features of each character.

Character Design

- First Soldier (victim): Soft facial features were chosen for this character to emphasise his vulnerability and compassion. His medium build and not overly expressive features help viewers easily identify him as an ordinary soldier in distress. The soldier's clothing has been designed with his military specialisation and battlefield conditions in mind.

- The second soldier (antagonist): This character is endowed with sharp facial features and a large build, which gives him the appearance of confidence and aggressiveness. His appearance evokes a sense of threat and tension in the audience. The antagonist's clothing is stricter and more militant to emphasise his military role.

- An ordinary citizen (spectator): This character is presented in normal everyday clothing, which helps to create a contrast between him and the soldiers. He is middle-aged, with simple messy hair and moderate physical activity.



Figure 5.3 – First Soldier (Victim)

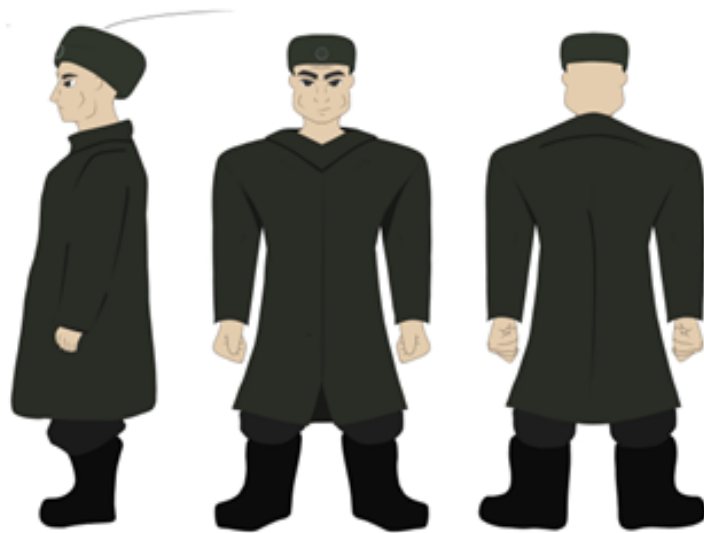


Figure 5.4 – The second soldier (antagonist)

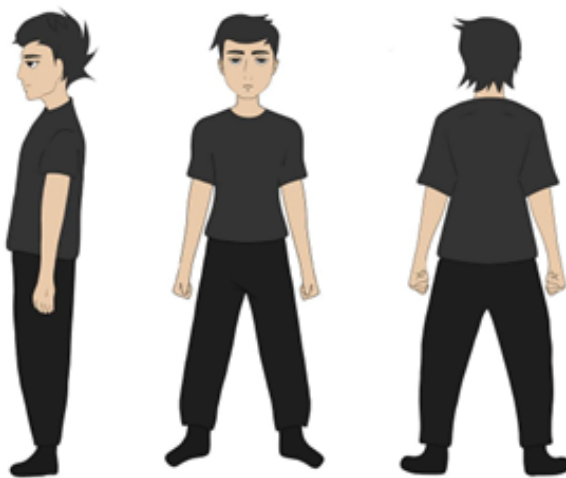


Figure 5.5 – An ordinary citizen (spectator)

Backgrounds in animation play an important role in creating atmosphere and help set the context for scenes. There are two main locations in our project - the battlefield outside and the room. For each of them, several backgrounds have been created from different angles to give the animation depth and realism.

The backgrounds of the battlefields have been detailed to capture the characteristic elements of such environments: ruins of buildings, smoke, wreckage of military equipment, etc. This helps to create a realistic and atmospheric picture.

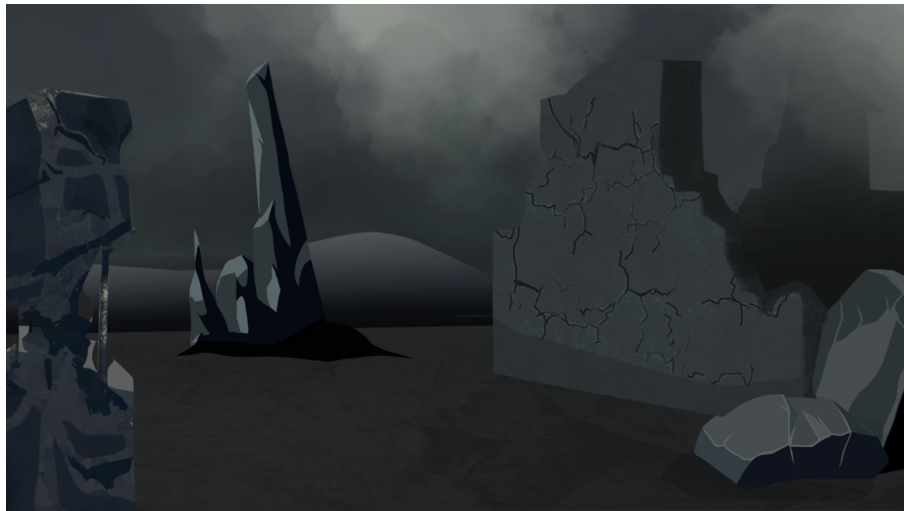


Figure 5.6 – Example of a background (battlefield)

The backgrounds of the room are carefully designed to convey an atmosphere of cosiness or tension, depending on the storyline. This applies to furniture, decorations, lighting and other elements that help create the right mood.



Figure 5.7 – Example of a background (room)

5.2.5 Palette creation

To create an effective atmosphere and convey emotion, the animation chooses 2 main color palettes for different scenes.

Scenes with heroic action are dominated by calmer and darker shades such as blue, grey, and green. These colors create an atmosphere of confidence and calmness, emphasizing the events' heroic nature.



Figure 5.8 – Color palette (1)

Scenes with danger and tension are brighter and more disturbing colors such as red, orange, and black are chosen for these scenes. These colors create an atmosphere of tension and danger, which helps to convey the aggressiveness and threat of the situation.

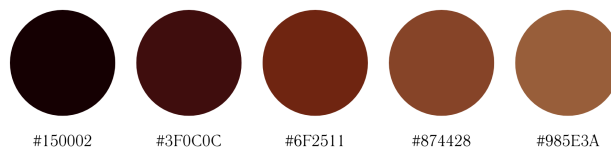


Figure 5.9 – Color palette (2)

A palette of dark blue shades was created for the room's backgrounds to create an atmosphere of calm and coziness, contrasting with the chaos and tension of the outside scenes.

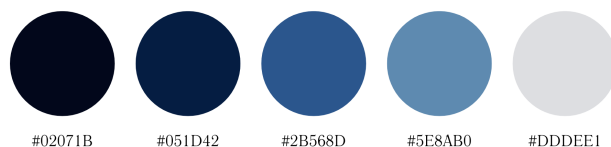


Figure 5.10 – Color palette (3)

Having completed the Pre-production stage, we moved on to the next stage - Production. At this stage, the animation is directly created.

The animation was done at 12 frames per second (fps), which is typical for many animation projects. The animation style was taken into account when choosing this number of frames. Animation at 12 frames per second has a distinctive look and feel. It allows you to create expressive, subtly stylized movements that fit the genre of the project. It's also important to remember that animating at 12 frames per second requires less time and resources than animating at 24 or 30 frames per second. This is especially important for independent projects.

5.2.6 Animation (Key frames & In-between)

The first step in creating an animation is to create a rough cut. This is an important step that lays the foundation for all subsequent stages of animation. At the very beginning, keyframes are created. They determine the main moments of character movement and scene changes. At this stage, the main poses and expressions of characters, as well as important moments of interaction with the environment are worked out. After that, in-between frames were added. These frames fill in the gaps between keyframes, making the movements smooth and natural. Working with intermediate frames requires special attention to detail to ensure smooth and uninterrupted movement.

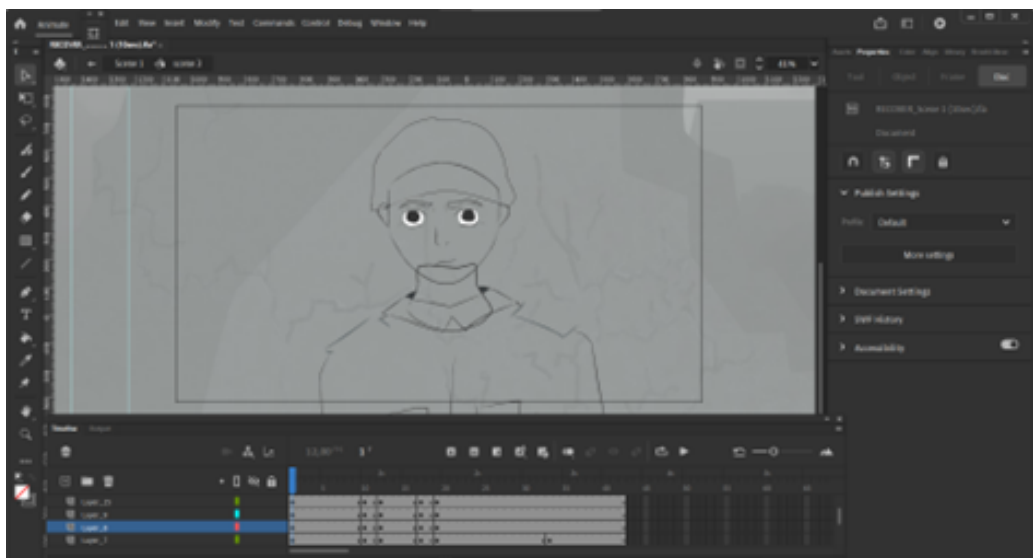


Figure 5.11

5.2.7 Cleaning and coloring

Having completed the rough cut and finalized the keyframes, we moved on to the creation of "clean animation". In clean animation is a detailed processing of all frames. At this stage all unnecessary lines and traces are removed, fine details are

added and nuances of character movements are worked out. Also in the clean-up phase, small details such as textures, creases on clothing, small facial expression elements, and other features were added to help bring the characters to life and make them more realistic.

With the animation finished and looking clean, we move on to the colouring process. In this stage, we add color to each frame of the animation. According to the pre-designed palettes for the different scenes, primary and secondary colors were chosen for each character.

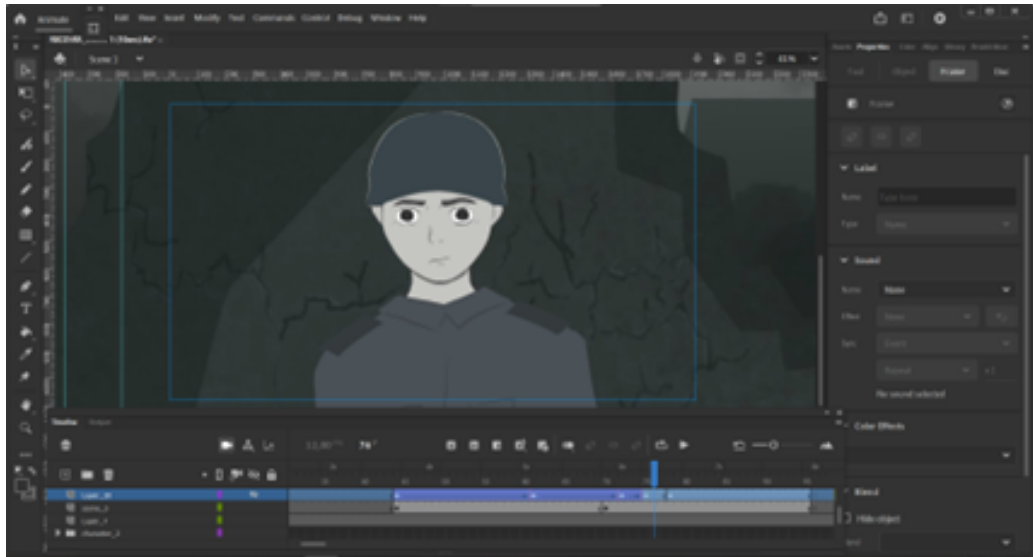


Figure 5.12

5.2.8 Compositing

Compositing is the final stage of production where all the elements of an animation are combined into a whole piece of work. This process involved integrating various visual layers, adding special effects, and final color adjustment. At the compositing stage, all created layers - background, characters, effects - are combined into a single composition. Special effects, final color palette adjustments, and additional light and shadow work in another editor (Adobe After Effects) were also added.

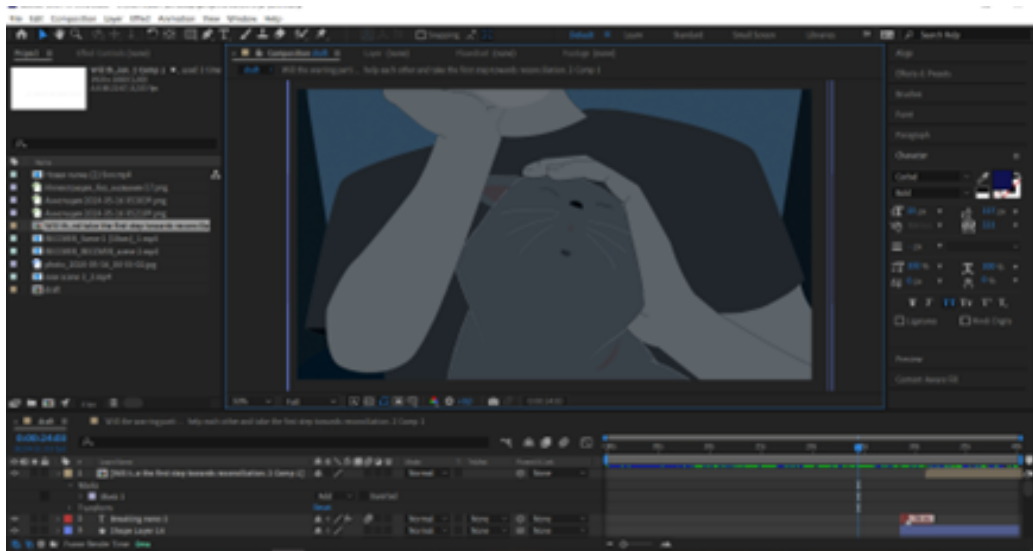


Figure 5.13 – Compositing process in Adobe After Effects

After finishing the compositing stage, we moved on to post-production. This includes editing, sound design, and final rendering.

5.2.9 Editing

Editing is the process of connecting all the scenes and shots in a sequence to create a logical and coherent narrative. All the scenes and footage have been combined into a single timeline. Various transitions (smooth transitions, blackouts and overlays) were used to make the scenes flow smoothly into one another.

5.2.10 Sound effects

Sound effects and music were added to give realism and the right atmosphere. Some environmental sounds were taken from free sources on the internet, while others, such as footsteps and TV sounds, were created independently. Final mixing was done after all the sound elements were added. This is a process in which the volume levels of each sound element are regulated to make everything sound harmonious and balanced.

After completing all stages of editing, the final check of the animated film was carried out. At this moment it is necessary to make sure that all elements of the animation film work coherently, without technical problems and visual inconsistencies. In addition, we make sure that the sound quality and synchronization with the visual effects are at the highest level.

5.2.11 Rendering

The final step in creating an animation is rendering. This is the process that turns all the work into a product ready for viewing. We chose the following rendering parameters: a resolution of 1920x1080 (Full HD) and a frame rate of 12 frames per second. We also selected the MP4 format, H.264 codec and High

Quality 1080p HD preset, which ensures good quality with a relatively small file size. After configuring all the parameters, we started the rendering process in the Adobe Media Encoder program. This stage took a significant amount of time, but we didn't encounter any errors or defects.

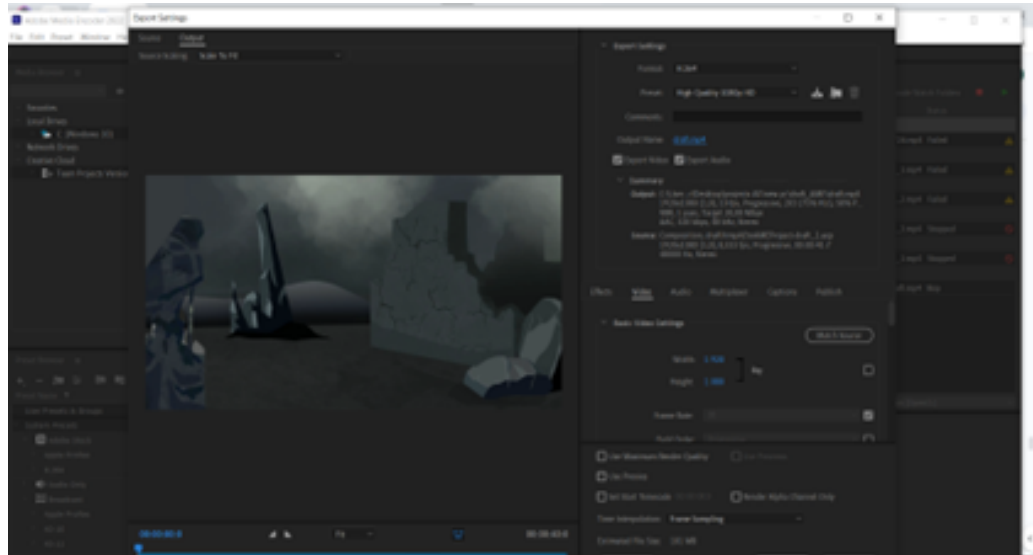


Figure 5.14 – Rendering in Adobe Media Encoder

5.3 TESTING

In the testing phase, the rendered animation was played back to check for errors in animation objects, character positioning and movement, after which it moved to the final phase, the distribution phase.

Table 5.1

№	Actions	Result	
		Yes	No
1.	Checking the animation's storyline alignment with the storyboard	Yes	No
2.	Checking the animation's color scheme	+	
3.	Checking the animation characters	+	
4.	Checking the animation background	+	
5.	Testing the sound and music	+	
6.	Checking the suitability of filters and animation effects.	+	

5.4 APPLICATION INSTRUMENT DESIGN

Application tools used in 2D animation development can be divided into two categories:

Software:

- 1 Procreate v5.3.8:
 - Usage: Storyboard creation, character, and background design.
 - Description: Procreate is a powerful digital drawing and illustration app for iPad. It allows you to create detailed sketches and illustrations, making it ideal for the preliminary stages of animation work.
- 2 Adobe Animate 2023:
 - Usage: Creating 2D animation
 - Description: Adobe Animate is a professional animation creation program. All keyframes and in-between frames have been created in it.
- 3 Adobe After Effects:
 - Usage: Compositing
 - Description: Adobe After Effects is a visual effects and compositing program. It is used for combining all layers of animation, adding special effects, and final rendering.
- 4 Adobe Media Encoder CS 2022:
 - Usage: Final rendering
 - Description: Adobe Media Encoder CS is a tool that converts video from various formats to high-quality playback

Hardware:

- 5 ASUS VivoBook 15 K513:
 - Usage: A basic device for animation development.
 - Description: A laptop with an Intel Core i7 processor, NVIDIA GeForce MX330 graphics card, 16GB of RAM and 512GB SSD storage.
- 6 iPhone 13:
 - Usage: Creating sound effects.
 - Description: The smartphone is used to record and process sound effects needed for sound design animations.
- 7 10th generation iPad:
 - Usage: Work with Procreate to create storyboards, characters, and backgrounds.
 - Description: A tablet used for digital drawing and illustration
- 8 Parblo Ninos A5 graphics tablet:
 - Usage: Drawing on a laptop
 - Description: Graphic tablet used for accurate and comfortable drawing

Table 5.2

№	Category Title	Description	Price
Hardware			
1.	ASUS VivoBook 15 K513	A basic tool for animation and editing.	289 990 tg
2.	10th-generation iPad	Used for drawing storyboards and character designs.	259 990 tg
3.	Parblo Ninos A5 graphics tablet	Provides precise control for digital artwork and animation	24 000 tg
4.	iPhone 13	Recording sound effects	329 990 tg
Software			
1.	Procreate	Creating storyboards and initial sketches.	10 000 tg
2.	Adobe Creative Cloud (annual subscription)	A comprehensive software package for animation, compositing and rendering.	240 000 tg
Total amount			1 153 970 tg

5.5 MARKETING AND DISTRIBUTION STRATEGY

The goal of the marketing and distribution strategy for our animation is to engage a broad audience, raise awareness of the media's influence on public opinion in the context of military conflicts, and create dialogue around this important topic. We aim to achieve these goals through targeted marketing efforts and carefully planned content distribution.

Marketing strategy

- Social Media: Promoting through platforms such as Instagram, Facebook, and TikTok using hashtags.
- Video platforms: Publishing animation on YouTube and Vimeo using premiere and streaming features to attract attention.
- Animation Festivals: Submit to international and national animation festivals.

Performance monitoring and evaluation

- Surveys and questionnaires: Conducting surveys among viewers to get their opinions and feedback.
- Discussions: Monitoring comments and discussions on social media.

6 LIMITATIONS

Sample size. The study analyzed only 22 news articles from 8 news portals from 4 countries. This sample coverage may not fully reflect the wide range of media coverage and public perceptions of events. In addition, the news portals analyzed are only represented in four countries, which may lead to geographical and cultural bias in the analysis. Media coverage and public perception may differ in other regions.

Subjectivity in Frame Analysis. Frame analysis inherently involves a certain level of subjectivity in identifying and categorizing frames. Different researchers may interpret and categorize frames differently, which can affect the results of the analysis.

Limited features. Some specific functions required for animation and compositing were not available in the used versions of the program. This imposed limitations on realizing some creative ideas and made it necessary to find alternative ways of implementing them.

Compatibility. The software tools and plug-ins we used didn't always work well together, causing additional problems and delays. For instance, when transferring data between Adobe Animate and After Effects, we needed to take extra steps to fix the formats and adjust the animations.

Cultural and social aspects. Given the complexity and sensitivity of the topic of military conflicts, it was necessary to carefully select content to avoid inadvertent offence or misinterpretation. This imposed restrictions on creative freedom and required additional analyses and adjustments to scenes.

CONCLUSION

The study examines the complex relationship that exists between public opinion and the media during armed conflict and emphasizes how crucial it is to understand how audience reactions and opinions shape media coverage. Numerous theoretical foundations and methods used by the media in attempts to influence public opinion during conflicts have been studied during an extensive literature review.

Thus, the research identified specific methods and strategies of media during military conflicts, including the sequential and fragmented ways of information dissemination, disinformation strategy, and the strategy of discrediting. To demonstrate the effect of media strategies on the formation of public opinion, examples from real conflicts, in particular the Russian-Ukrainian military conflict, were analyzed.

The comparative content analysis conducted as part of the research allowed us to examine news stories from various sources and to identify the variety of strategies used by state and non-state media to shape public opinion during the Russian-Ukrainian conflict. Frame analysis allowed for a detailed examination of the analyzed news stories, identifying the dominant narratives presented by different media outlets. Key phrases, metaphors, and recurrent themes were studied and classified into four frames: war crimes-focused, accusation-focused, compassion-focused, and victim-focused. The findings emphasize the key role of the media in influencing public sentiment and perception, especially in the context of information warfare.

The 2D animated short film developed made it possible to effectively visualize the results of content research, making abstract data more specific and understandable. This is an effective way to demonstrate media bias and agenda setting, as well as to illustrate the impact of media manipulation on a person and the importance of different points of view in news coverage.

In conclusion, this study contributes to the corpus of knowledge already in existence by highlighting the complex ways in which the media shapes public opinion during military conflicts. By identifying key strategies and techniques used by media actors, the study seeks to contribute to a better understanding of the diversity and functioning of media strategies to manipulate audience opinion during conflicts.

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